

SOUMITRA GHOSH

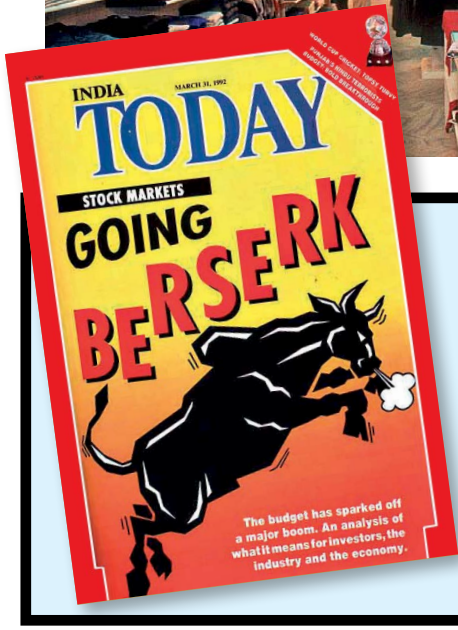


FULL STEAM AHEAD
(Clockwise from left), an INDIA TODAY cartoon on Manmohan seeing the 'big picture'; Aamir Khan in a 1993 Pepsi ad, the same year Coke returned to India; a Benetton outlet in the '90s



banding—one licence for multiple sectors—and relaxed some import duties.

Rajiv's big, visionary, epoch-making move, though, was elsewhere. Under Sam Pitroda and his technology missions, it laid the groundwork for digital India and modern mobile networks. It also began freeing up the aviation sector by allowing private players as 'air taxi operators'. The open-skies policy took full wing under Rao, yielding India's first private airline in decades, East West. On terra firma, Rajiv decentralised power with the Panchayati Raj reforms, and tended to the basics with the National Drinking Water Mission. ■



STOCK MARKETS: GOING BERSERK
Mar. 31, 1992

"At 6.30 pm, on February 29, as finance minister Manmohan Singh read out the budget, more than two lakh investors at the Jeejeebhoy Towers, where BSE is located, kept their pens poised over hefty cheque books. And in the two-hour post-budget trading session they—metaphorically speaking—signed away cheques worth more than Rs 200 crore. Or, roughly Rs 1.6 crore per minute was pumped into the stock-market in Bombay alone. Despite the 50-per cent margins imposed by exchange authorities on key scrips to curb speculation, nothing could stop the charge."